the July 26th Movement. The *llano* (plains, in contrast to the sierra or mountains) strategy aimed to force Batista's resignation through urban insurrection. Julia Sweig argues that from 1957–58 the urban underground wing of the Movement, led by middle class youth and focusing on acts of sabotage leading up to a general strike, held center stage in Cuba's revolutionary war. It was only after the general strike planned for April, 1958 failed that Fidel and Che's sierra movement emerged preeminent in the revolutionary coalition.[47]

Curiously, a U.S. journalist, writing for the *New York Times*, gave Fidel Castro's sierra guerrillas' revolt an unexpected boost and contributed to the sierra's mythmaking qualities. *Times* reporter Herbert L. Matthews travelled into the sierra to interview Fidel in February, 1957, just months after the failed *Granma* expedition. His explosive report appeared on the front page of the *Times* and brought Castro into U.S. living rooms. "He has strong ideas of liberty, democracy, social justice, the need to restore the Constitution, to hold elections," Matthews reported. Another *Times* reporter would later dub Matthews "the man who invented Fidel."[48]

Until March of 1958, the United States stood behind its ally Batista, supplying his government with arms and ammunition. Just as the rebels were unifying and gaining strength, the government lost its most important pillar of support when the United States cut off military aid. What Batista hoped would be a final offensive against the rebels in the summer of 1958 failed, and the rebel counteroffensive that begin in August proved inexorable. Batista's army, though large and well equipped, was poorly trained and poorly motivated. As 1958 drew to a close, the rebel armies took city after city and moved in on the capital, as the United States scrambled ineffectually to derail a July 26 victory or to impose an alternative that they believed would be more amenable to U.S. control.[49]

Much ink has been spent in the United States trying to pinpoint when, exactly, the Cuban Revolution became a socialist revolution, or when Fidel Castro became a Communist. It's important to remember that Communist and other Marxist political parties and organizations have